

KEEP THIS ONE; IT'S BUILT TO LIVE ON YOUR DESK

Prompting Basics: Getting Useful Results Every Time

THE FORMULA

Role · Task · Context · Format

Then iterate: content, voice, details.

The four parts

Part	The question it answers	Example
Role	Who should the AI be?	"You are an experienced 4th grade teacher."
Task	What exactly do you want? One clear verb.	"Draft a 45-minute introductory lesson on equivalent fractions."
Context	What would a substitute need to know?	"The class has mastered notation but confuses numerator and denominator when simplifying."
Format	What should the output look like?	"A table with timings; include a 3-question exit check."

The colleague test: before you hit enter, imagine showing the prompt to a colleague with zero context. If they'd be confused, the model will be too. (Straight from the AI companies' own documentation.)

The spice rack: four small upgrades

- **Constraints:** "under 150 words" · "exactly five questions" · "no materials that need a copier"
- **Audience:** "for students who have never seen this word" · "for families skimming on a phone"
- **An example:** paste one sample in the style you want and say "match this style"
- **Escape hatch:** "Ask me up to three clarifying questions before you start."

A makeover, start to finish

Before "Write a note to parents about the field trip."

After "You are a warm, organized elementary teacher. Write a note to families about an upcoming museum field trip. Context: departure 8:30 a.m., return by 2 p.m., students need a bagged lunch and a signed permission slip by Friday. Reading level: busy families skimming on a phone. Format: under 150 words, three action items as a bulleted list."

Iterate in three rounds (the first draft is a proposal)

Round	Ask yourself	Say to the AI
1 · Content	What's wrong or missing?	"Question 4 is too hard for the start of the unit."
2 · Voice	Does it sound like me?	"Warmer. Fewer exclamation points. I'd never say 'furthermore.'"
3 · Details	Length, level, layout right?	"Shorten by a third; make the directions a numbered list."

Iterate vs. start over: eighty percent right, iterate. Wrong thing entirely, start a fresh prompt and fold what you learned into the context.

Template it: your reusable prompt

"You are a [grade/subject] teacher. Create a [number]-question review on [topic] for students who [what they struggle with]. Format: [format]. Include an answer key."

Build once, fill in the blanks forever. Save yours in the staff prompt doc with your name and a one-line note. Nobody at this school solves the same problem twice.

What prompting can't do

- **It can't turn off hallucination.** Verify anything factual, always.
- **It can't know your students.** Personalizing is your part, after the draft comes back.
- **It can't decide what's worth teaching.** That was never a formatting problem.

The permanent rules ride along: no student personally identifiable information in public AI tools, ever. And a human reviews everything before it reaches a student or family.

My reusable prompt (draft it here first)

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